

Is Social Media Built for Sharing Outrage?

Testing Negative language, follower counts and repost activity in English political posts on Bluesky

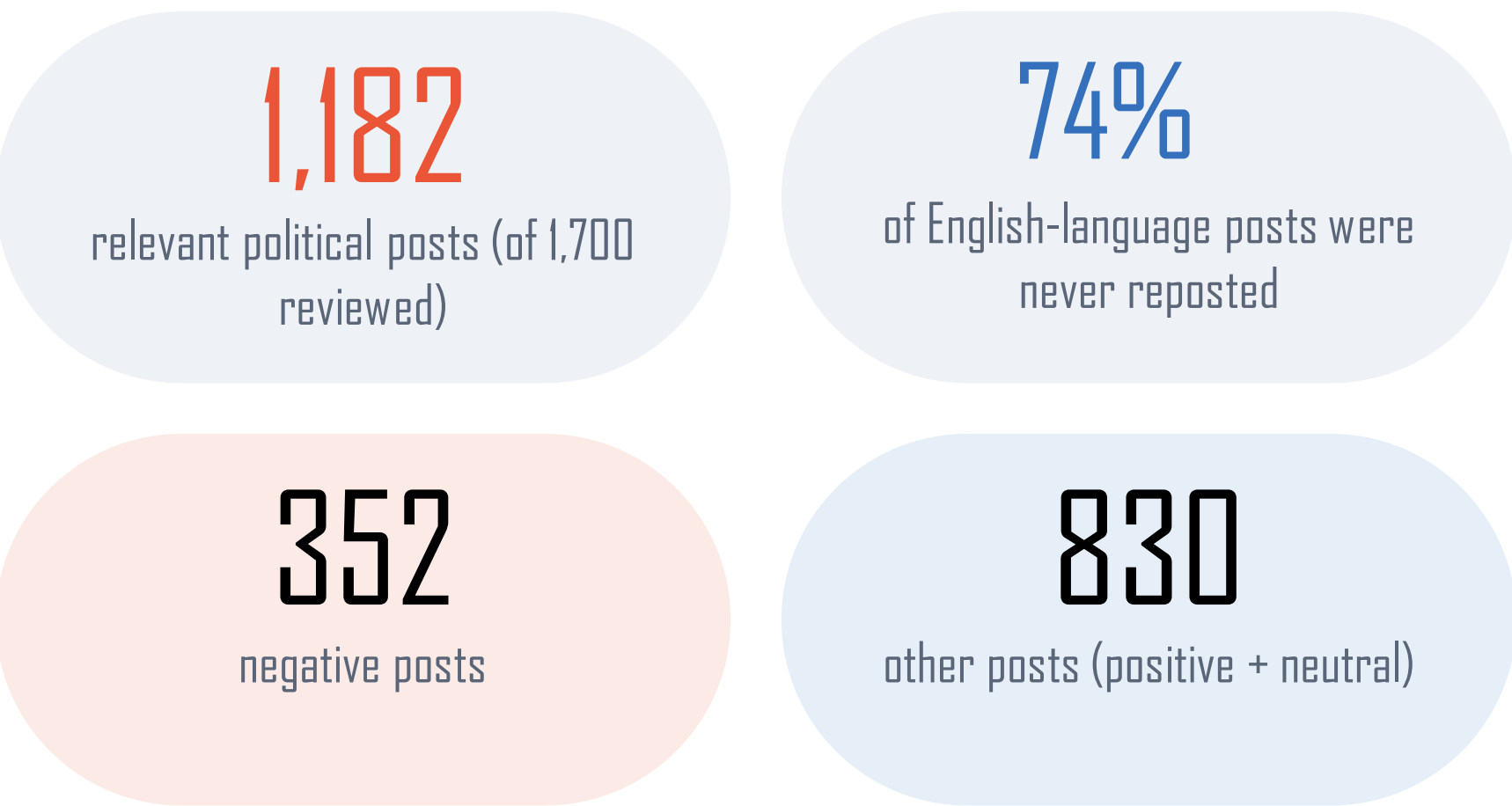
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Main Question:

Do English political posts with negative language receive more reposts than other posts on Bluesky, regardless of follower count?

1) Background & data

Negative political opinions spread fast social media, and we're often left wondering how much of what we see online reflects the broader opinion of society. So, we put that to the test by checking if negative language itself is the actual driver, and how popular accounts could play a role in the spread.



We used the search terms: immigration, inflation, housing crisis, unemployment, wages, and political discussion.

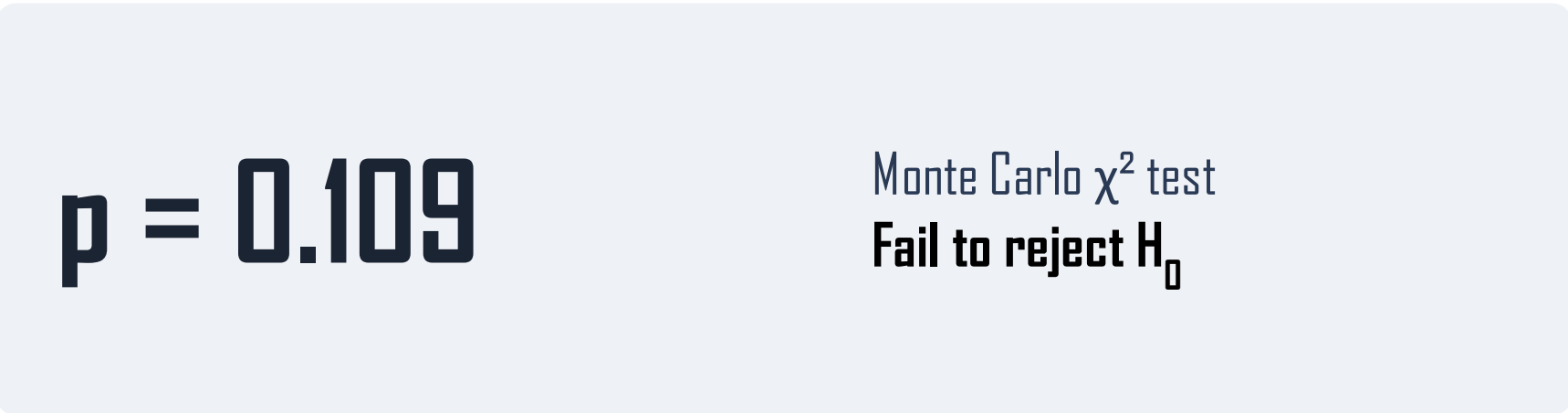
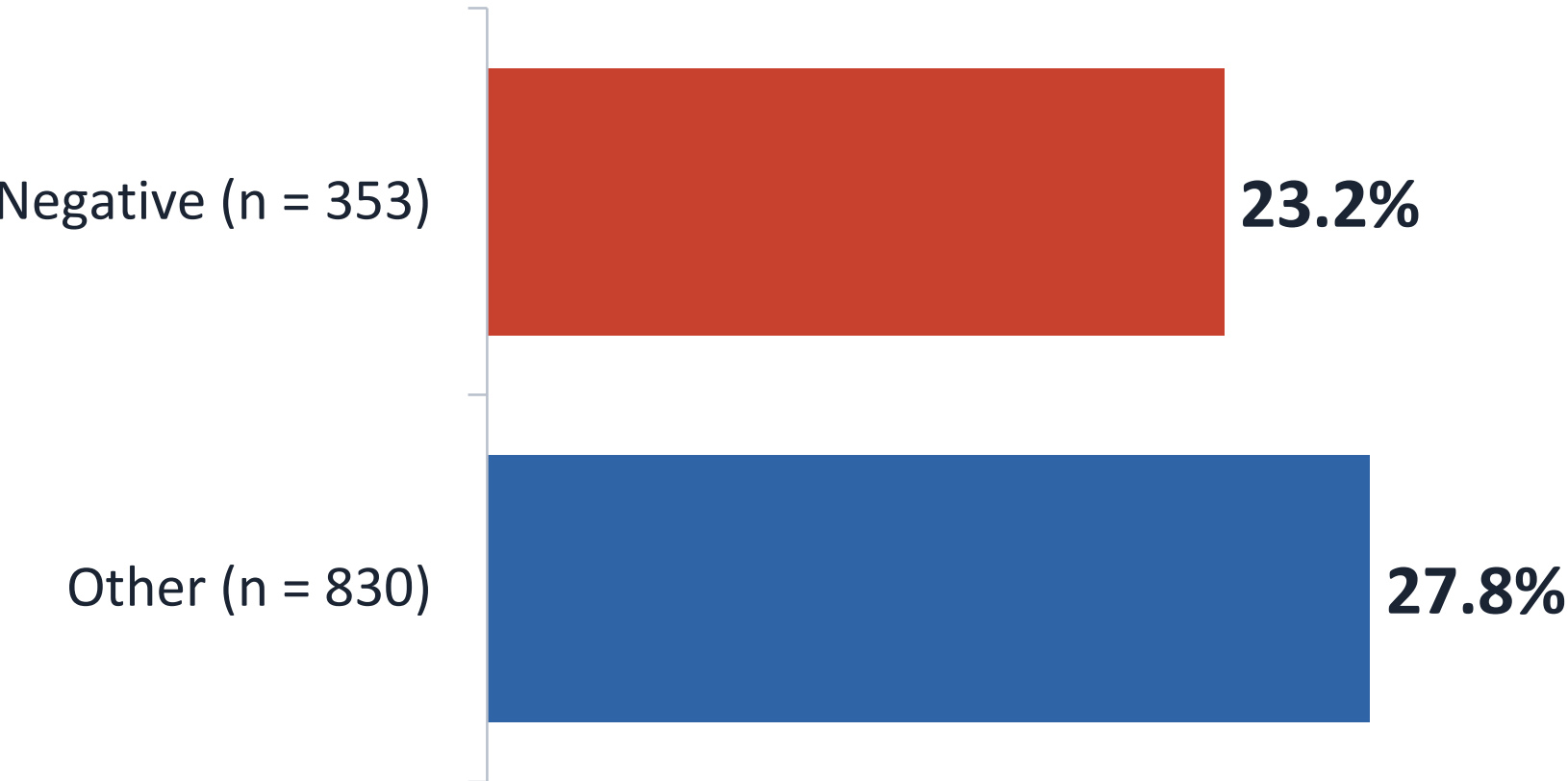
Collected with *atrrrr* in R: post text, authors, repost and like counts, follower counts and individual reposts.

2) Sentiment vs reposts

Are negative posts more likely to be reposted?

H_0 Sentiment and repost activity are independent.
 H_A Sentiment and repost activity are associated.

Posts receiving at least one repost (%)

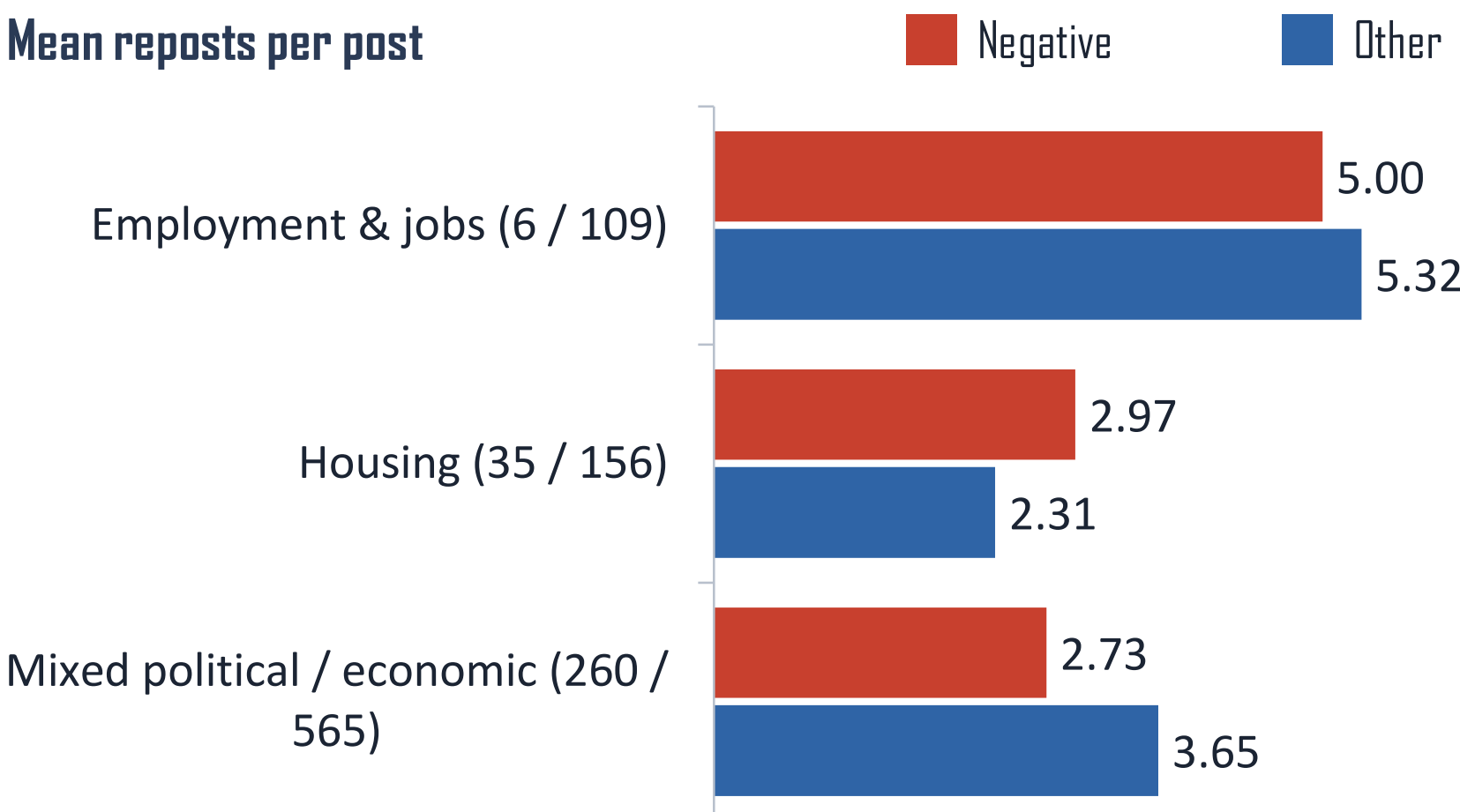


Negative posts were reposted slightly less often (82 of 353 vs 231 of 830), and the difference is not statistically significant. This test did not control for follower count.

3) Topic clusters

Does negativity get more reposts within topics?

Grouped posts with similar wording into four clusters using TF-IDF, cosine distance, MDS and k-means. Sentiment and repost counts were compared afterwards. The clusters covered petitions, employment, housing and mixed political/economic discussion.



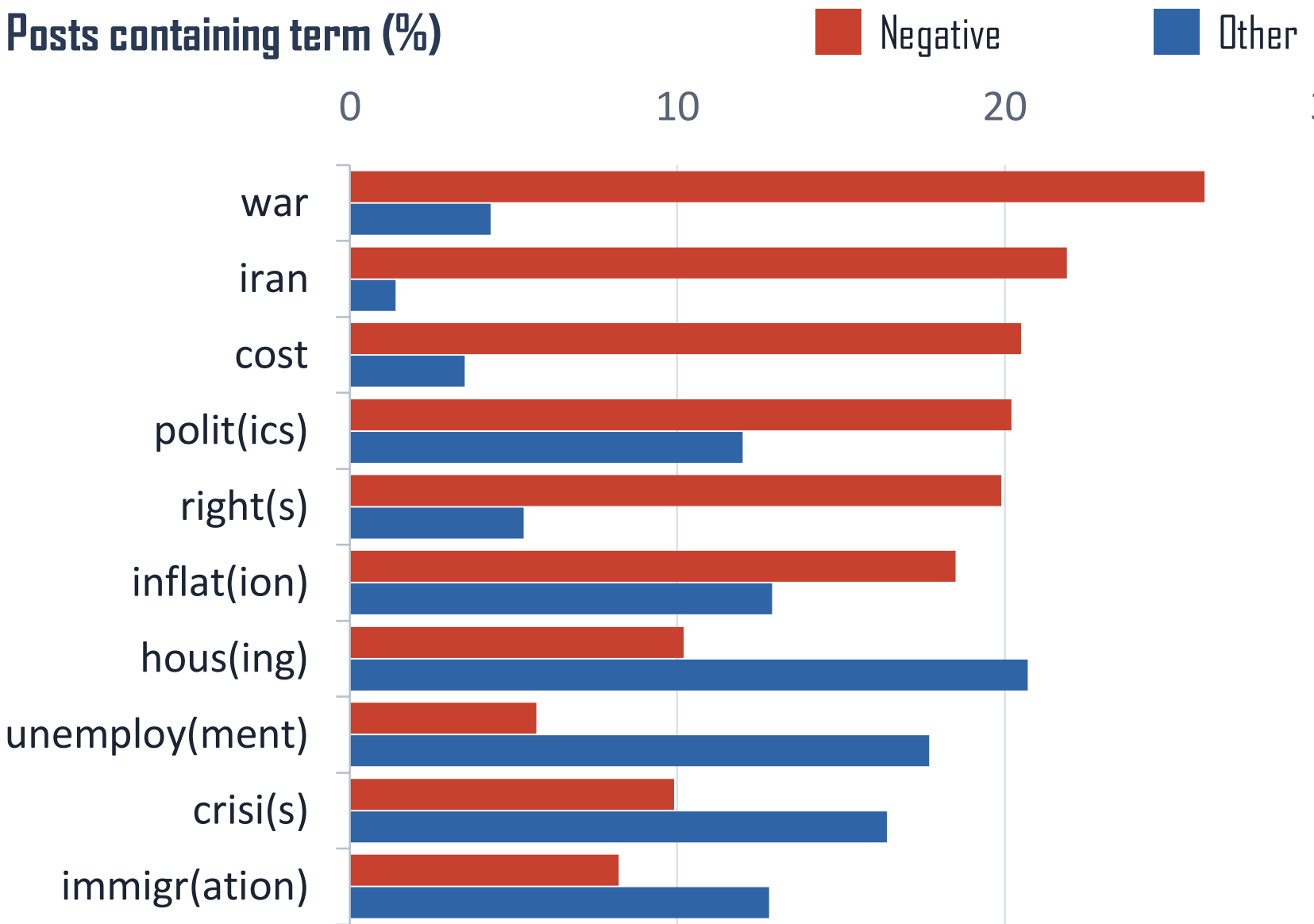
Negative-labelled posts had higher average reposts only in housing (2.97 vs 2.31). Employment and mixed discussion showed the opposite, so **negative posts had no consistent advantage**. Most medians were zero. The petition cluster had 51 posts but just seven distinct texts, showing how often the wording was repeated.

The petition cluster (51 posts) had no 'other' posts to compare with, and employment had just 6 negative-labelled posts. Brackets show negative / other post counts. These comparisons are descriptive only.

4) Prominent words

What do negative posts talk about?

We compared the percentage of posts containing each word stem, counting it once per post to account for different group sizes. This helps show whether the groups discuss different issues, giving context to the repost comparison.

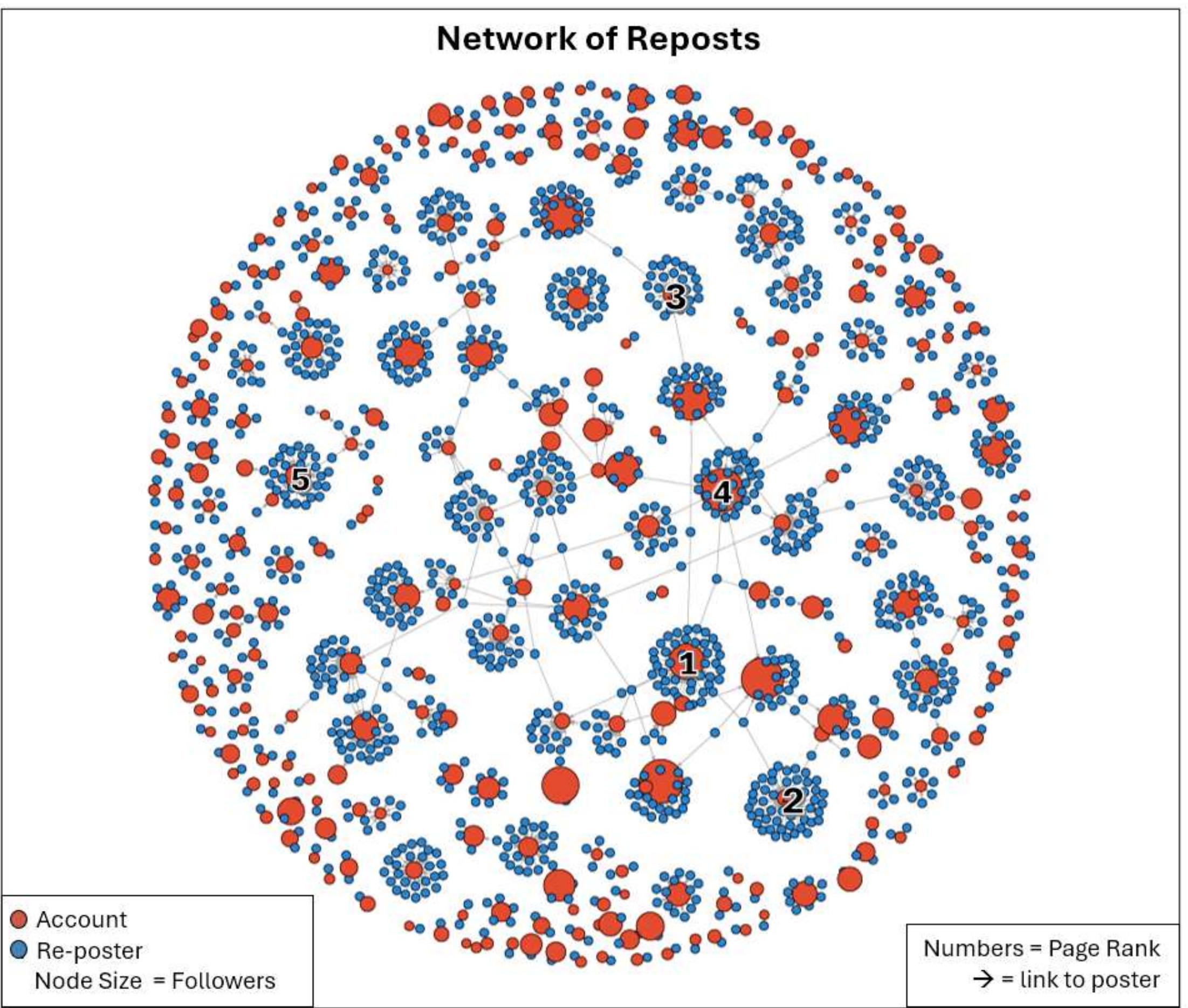


Negative-labelled posts more often mention **war**, **Iran** and **cost**. Other posts more often mention **housing**, **unemployment** and **crisis**. These topic differences may help explain the repost patterns. **war** appeared in 26.1% of negative-labelled posts, compared with 4.3% of other posts.

5) The repost network

Who's doing the reposting?

We wanted to see whether larger followings are associated with the broader sharing of posts, so we built a network of the reposts, removing duplicate pairs and self reposts so that each link to the poster was unique.



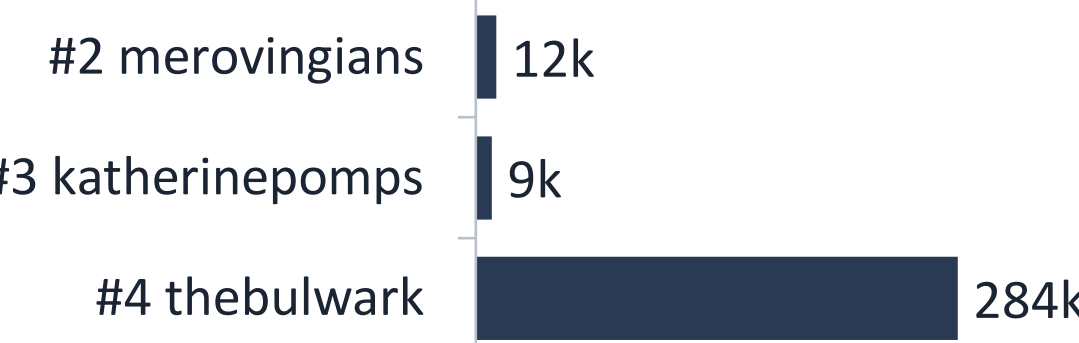
6) Centrality vs followers

Does a bigger following mean more relevance in the network?

So we measured two forms of centrality:



Followers of PageRank #2 - #4

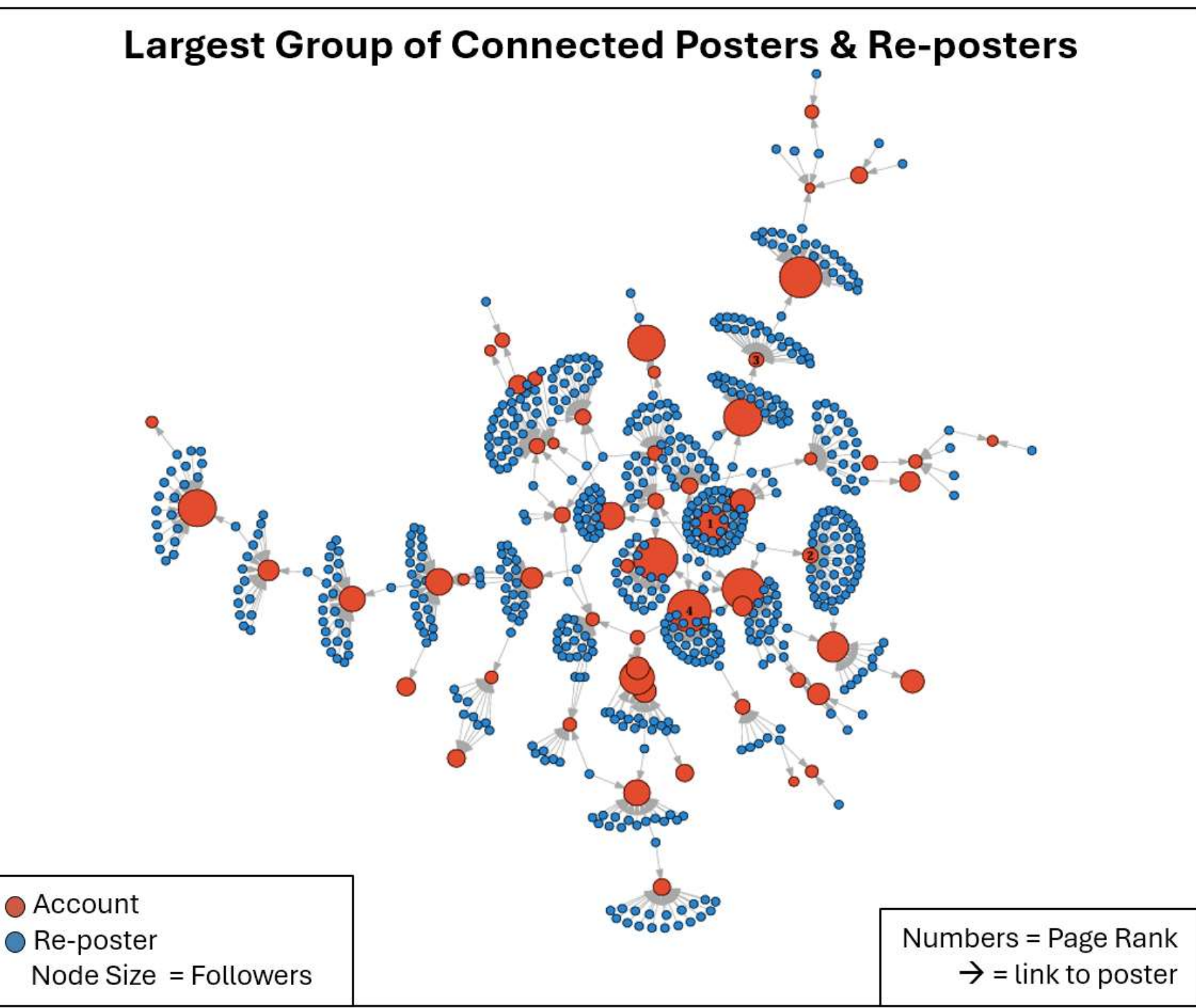


Katherinepomps ranked above jcollins (11k followers) in PageRank despite having fewer followers and re-posters, which suggests that raw follower counts may matter less than who shares your post.

4 out 5 accounts appear in both rankings.

7) Largest connected group

How connected is the sharing?



PageRank accounts #1-#4 are within this group, but #5 bencasselman remains in a separate group, meaning an account can rank highly while being its own group of re-poster, hence we shouldn't regard these sharing group for broader public opinion

Conclusion

No evidence found for negative political language gaining more reposts.

- Sentiment test was not significant ($p = 0.109$) as negative posts were reposted only slightly less often.
- No consistent advantages were seen for negative posts within topic clusters.
- Bigger followings did not guarantee higher PageRank, what mattered more was did the sharing.

Limitations: Keyword sampling limits how well findings represent Bluesky. Model detected only 14.7% of negative validation posts. Repeated wording, small groups and incomplete repost data limit comparisons. Follower count and post age were not controlled, hence causation cannot be established.